

A dual citizen of the United States and Germany, Lilly finished school and moved in with her parents, who are living in Switzerland. Her parents helped her pay for the private university she attended in California and took out loans for her under their name. They also gave her and her brother money to live on after school while they looked for work. Lilly's parents' friends who don't have children themselves point out that Lilly's parents could have spent that money on their own lives: vacations, nicer cars, newer homes. I argued that once you have kids, you should expect to spend more money taking care of them than your friends who don't have kids would spend on someone other than themselves. (My parents are in debt. My aunt and uncle who don't have children drive Mercedes-Benzes.)

According to a survey conducted in 2016 by the credit card company Discover, if a child takes out a student loan, their parents are now more willing to help pay it back than they were just four years earlier (61 percent, up from 55 percent). Half of those parents surveyed in 2016 said that they were "very worried that student debt may affect their child's ability to buy a house, car or other large purchase." A 2016 *Forbes* article, "More Parents Taking On Their Kids' College Debt," cited a University of Southern California study showing that 17 percent of parents "around age 50" are currently paying back their child's student loans. In the last decade or so, the amount that students borrowed in the United States has soared from \$3.6 billion to \$12 billion. Loans become not only the student's responsibility but a family burden.

Forbes thinks this is because baby boomers and Gen Xers, many of whom are parents and have debt themselves, don't fully understand the risks of cosigning student loans for their millennial or Gen Z kid until it's too late. More than half said the decision negatively affected their own credit scores and caused them to put off their retirement. The other problem is that they're borrowing more for student loans than parents and students in previous generations due to rising college tuition. According to *U.S. News & World Report*, the average total cost of attending a private university has jumped 157 percent in the last 20 years,